lots of money from taxation, helping the rich steal from everyone else. We don't want to cause that problem. I think digital payments are okay if the payer is anonymous. Here's a crucial point. With GNU Taler, the payee is always identified and hence, it does not promote tax dodging.

We identify the payee. So, if you paid for a service, it'd get something that it can submit to a bank or a similar entity, and get exchanged for money. This way, the transaction would get recorded with the bank.

Q. How does GNU Taler differ from cryptocurrencies?

A. GNU Taler has several advantages compared with cryptocurrencies. First, it doesn't fluctuate relative to the currency. And you'll avoid the speculation of cryptocurrencies. I've never used crypto; I don't like speculating.

Another difference is that it's more anonymous for the payer. With Bitcoin at least, every transaction is public because there are ways of figuring out who owns or uses a particular wallet. And the other thing is that it's always identified for the payee. And it's also much more efficient.

Q. How does it prevent the payer's information from being stored?

A. It uses blind signatures. Using an algorithm similar to RSA, you can arrange for someone else to sign a number for you and not know what number is signed. Essentially, you take a number and multiply it by a large prime and submit the product to be signed. Since you know that it's signed in a certain way, such that you know what the two factors were, you can deduce the signed version of the original number by dividing out that other prime. So, you now have a token that can be validated by the bank. But no one can tell that it came through you.

Q. When I buy a car, it now comes with non-free software and spyware. What's the respite then?

A. Nowadays, there are connected cars which have cellular data communication. And if that's operating, it can determine its location if anyone tells it to. But not if you disconnect it. Also, the GPS system, which shows you where you are, probably remembers all your locations as well. If you get the car serviced, someone can look in that and find out wherever you've been. That's the road to tyranny.

You wouldn't want any government to have that kind of power. But if you disconnect the GPS antenna, then it won't know where you are and obviously won't remember your locations. For each antenna, you have to either disconnect it or cover it with some sort of metal foil—a conductive foil that doesn't let radio waves through.

Those are the only things I believe you need to do. Though this is theoretical, it would be very interesting for people to try and verify that the system stopped working. One nice thing about these methods is that you can easily revert things back to how they were.

Q. There is an increasing trend where car companies are providing cars as a service. Toyota, for example, had proposed to charge $80 a year just for the facility of remotely locking and unlocking your car. BMW is offering heated seats in their cars as an optional service.

A. This is malicious; it's nasty behaviour. Selling you something that you cannot change is always bad. If you've got a car and you've just connected the data link antenna, then those services would work anyway. But if you disconnect, the related services won't function. That's what you have to expect.

Q. What are your thoughts on the emerging concept of the Internet of Things?

A. Well, we should respond to that with disgust. At the outset, I call it the Internet of Mal-things, or the Internet of Stings. Because although